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French 48

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Making Do of Translation

The main concepts of early translation theory were a product of its time. I will look over 3 excerpts from 2 historical figures and 1 wikipedia extra to analyze the main concepts of early translation theory. From my perspective, early translation theory is fragmented and spread out all over the place. There is not one standard consistent theoretical narrative that ties all the early effort of translation together at all. Instead, translators from old societies who did the labor of translating from language to another expressed their opinions on how to do it better. As such, many figures from different times and places would create informal terminology to describe the theoretical process of translation. What I think is important about early translation theory, is that translation was probably way harder in ancient times before technology and the internet. That's why excerpt 3, the Wikipedia help article "Help:Translation," says "articles on a given subject in different languages are typically edited independently, and need not correspond closely in form, style or content." The policy around editing the same topic in different languages independently most likely arose from the fact that the beginning of ancient civilizations with their own language and culture would create encyclopedias in their own language, as they had no need to amass knowledge in language not their own. Since cars, airplanes, telephones, satellites, and computers were not invented yet, accurate translation was super difficult. Without the modern amenities we have now, flying to another country, talking to foreigners online, or using computational techniques, verifying translations would be less of a concern than producing an adequate, approximate target text. I believe the translators from the scattered prefaces and the early works of translation theory were operating from a perspective of hardship and making things work despite the lack of knowledge they had.

I believe what links the scattered and marginalized early concepts of translation theory concerned the minimization of loss. I believe early translators found partial losses in meaning or intention of source texts to be inevitable because of the resources they had at the time. To expound, in excerpt 1, John Dryden's 1680 translation of Ovid's *Epistles*, discusses the concepts of early translation theory he applied to his translation, and even noted that this approach diverged from other theories of translation at the time. He wrote, in "this present work, the Reader will here find most of the Translations, with some little Latitude or variation from the Authours Sence," meaning that Dryden applied the early concept of "sense-for-sense" translation. This is the concept of translating a source text by taking the "sense" of a text, a term that scholars do not have a formal definition for, from the source language to the target language. As a result, Dryden wants to minimize what is lost from the source text by focusing on keeping the overall structure of the text there. This approach was systematic and could be applied to produce good approximations of thousands of works. Contrast this the previous authorities of translation in Dryden's time who believed "the praise of a Translation Consists in adding new Beauties to the piece, thereby to recompence the loss which it sustains by change of Language," who believed the loss was inevitable and thought to beauty in their own way to it to make a enjoyable piece of art. The problem with this approach is that the added beauty would not be part of the original sense and more would be lost. The second excerpt further enlightens the idea that

early translation theory had to deal with a lot of loss. It writes, “Up to now I have spoken as if I did change the letter somewhat, arguing that a simple translation can have mistakes without being criminal.” This again suggests that making a mistake in translation is part of the process and can’t be helped, so scholars interested in the theory of translation or creating translations deserving of praise had to devise a way to not lose the work and preserve it for the future no matter what language it is in. The final part of the excerpt really highlights concern of loss during this time:

“How much he omitted, how much he added, and how much he changed in order to display the properties of another language through the properties of his own, there is not enough time to say.”

The dramatic line, “there is not enough time to say,” just shows how much the loss of translation weighed on each of the translators of that time. Without the advantages of modern technology and global communication, these translators grappled with the inherent difficulties of their craft, often developing informal terminologies and methods on their own. Their recognition of inevitable loss and their attempts to mitigate it through approaches like sense-for-sense translation underscore a persistent dedication to preserving the essence of source texts.

In conclusion, the scattered and individualized efforts of early translators reveal a common thread of striving to minimize loss in the face of significant challenges. Despite the fragmented nature of early translation theory, these figures laid the groundwork for the more structured and systematic theories that would emerge later, highlighting the enduring human endeavor to bridge linguistic and cultural divides through translation.